

ASSESSING MY NEEDS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the negative impact of the current environment on recovery from addiction.
2. Identify connections between living environment deficiencies and addictive behavior and lifestyles.
3. Improve social, occupational, financial, and living situation sufficiently to increase the probability of successful recovery from addiction.
4. Prioritize needs for correcting environmental deficiencies and set goals to improve each.
5. Develop a peer group that is supportive of recovery.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE LIVING ENVIRONMENT DEFICIENCIES

- A Working Recovery Plan
- Assessing Self-Care Deficits
- Building My Support Network
- Filling in the Gaps
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Setting and Pursuing Goals in Recovery
- What Do I Need and How Do I Get It?
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Would My Ideal Life Look Like?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Medical Issues
- Self-Care Deficits—Primary
- Self-Care Deficits—Secondary

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Assessing My Needs” activity encourages clients in early recovery to become more aware of their living environments, assess what they may need to change to reduce their risk of relapse, plan strategies for those changes, and get feedback. This exercise can be used as an individual or group

activity. Follow-up with these clients could include sharing feedback received from program sponsors or others; tracking and reporting on progress on plans made; and other assignments, such as “Personal Recovery Planning” and “Relapse Prevention Planning.”

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Active addictive behavior and lifestyle may directly cause deficiencies in one's living environment. These can include limited support for recovery, social isolation, abusive or violent living environments, financial problems, and/or inadequate food and shelter. Some people are trying to work their recovery programs in environments that undermine abstinence and recovery. Often, they work very hard to succeed in recovery with these factors holding them back, when other ways are less risky and difficult. A big step for many is asking for help when they need it, before external stressors trigger a return to addictive behaviors. In this exercise you will assess how your current environment may sabotage your recovery or set you up to experience other problems, decide what you want to work on first, and then develop a plan to work on each unmet need. After completing this exercise, you will be responsible for following through on the plan you have created for yourself.

1. What are the problems in your living environment in the following areas?

Family life: _____

Social: _____

Occupational: _____

Financial: _____

Spiritual: _____

Neighborhood: _____

Recovery support: _____

Necessities for daily living (food, shelter, clothing, etc.): _____

2. List up to 10 ways your current living environment hurts your recovery efforts.

3. In what ways do your peers and family increase your risk of relapse (e.g., are they actively using, angry with you due to past behaviors, unsupportive of your recovery)?

4. What other problems do you experience in your living environment (e.g., abuse, violence)?

5. Pick the three most important deficiencies in your environment to work on first.

6. What are five actions you can take to improve things in the areas that you have listed as your most important deficiencies? These actions don't have to be dramatic. Think about a series of small steps.

7. Consult with your sponsor or someone you trust for other alternatives if you cannot think of five on your own. Have someone you trust review your completed exercise and write the feedback he/she gives you here.

Be sure to bring this handout with you to your next therapy session, and be prepared to discuss your thoughts and feelings about the exercise with your therapist.